Till 2014, it was clear that Priyanka had drawn a Lakshmanrekha on her involvement in politics. Whenever a Congressman publicly implored her to contest elections, her office issued a strong denial. ‘If I decide to enter politics, I won’t do it in some secretive manner,’ she would tell me. The 2009 election victory appeared to settle any doubts as to who would take forward the family legacy. A doting sister, Priyanka seemed content to remain in Rahul’s shadow, their us-versus-the-rest relationship most famously captured in the photograph of the siblings arm in arm in mutual consolation after the UP defeat in 2012.

The year 2014, though, was different. The Congress was in serious trouble and Rahul’s leadership was under the scanner. Priyanka was still unwilling to play a formal role in the party’s decision-making, but it was clear that her involvement was growing beyond Amethi. She would be spotted visiting Rahul’s house while strategy meetings were on and she had been involved with the Congress advertisement campaign with every creative being shown to her. ‘She may not have been hands-on, but she certainly wasn’t hands off,’ is how a Congress insider describes her presence.

From early April, Priyanka was in Amethi and Rae Bareli. Her brother and mother were the party’s main campaigners elsewhere; she was needed to keep the family turf secure. Amethi was no longer a safe constituency—in the 2012 assembly elections, the SP had won three of the five segments, the Congress just two (they had lost all the Rae Bareli seats too). Rahul had done some good work in the area—most notably, a women’s self-help group project—but UP’s perennial issues, especially bijli, sadak, pani and shiksha troubled the residents here as well. *‘Sir, yahan toh andhera hi andhera hai’* (There is darkness everywhere),’ is how one Amethi resident put it to me.

In fact, one could sense a growing frustration amongst the people about Amethi’s stagnant condition. At more than one ‘Nukkad Sabha’ that Priyanka addressed, she would have to listen to irate villagers speaking out: *‘Priyankaji, dus saal ho gaye, Rahulji ke aane se kuch nahin badla’* (Ten years have passed, nothing has changed with Rahulji coming here). The